

ASSESSMENT TOOL III – PENETRATION TESTING TASK

COURSE CODE: ITA1412

COURSE NAME: Ethical Hacking

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QUESTION 1 – EXTERNAL RECONNAISSANCE USING THEHARVESTER

Aim

To examine the publicly available footprint of the authorized domain **tesla.com** using theHarvester and determine what information can be obtained through passive reconnaissance techniques.

Tool Required

theHarvester

Target Domain

tesla.com

Purpose of the Experiment

The purpose of this exercise is to understand how information published on public sources can reveal details about an organization's external infrastructure. The collected information can then be categorized and evaluated from a security perspective.

Methodology

TheHarvester was executed against the authorized domain to collect information available through supported public sources. The reconnaissance focused on identifying:

- Public email addresses
- Subdomains
- Hostnames
- IP addresses
- URLs
- Domain-related infrastructure
- Other publicly indexed information

Command Executed

theHarvester -d tesla.com -b all

```
kali@kali: ~
Session Actions Edit View Help
zsh: corrupt history file /home/kali/.zsh_history
(kali@kali)~$ theHarvester -h
Read proxies.yaml from /etc/theHarvester/proxies.yaml
*****
* theHarvester 4.10.1
* Coded by Christian Martorella
* Edge-Security Research
* cmartorella@edge-security.com
*****
usage: theHarvester [-h] -d DOMAIN [-l LIMIT] [-s START] [-p] [-s] [--screenshot SCREENSHOT] [-e DNS_SERVER] [-t]
                  [-r [DNS_RESOLVE]] [-n] [-c] [-f FILENAME] [-w WORDLIST] [-a] [-q] [-b SOURCE]

theHarvester is used to gather open source intelligence (OSINT) on a company or domain.

options:
  -h, --help                show this help message and exit
  -d, --domain DOMAIN        company name or domain to search.
  -l, --limit LIMIT          limit the number of search results, default=500.
  -s, --start START          start with result number X, default=0.
  -p, --proxies              use proxies for requests, enter proxies in proxies.yaml.
  -s, --shodan              use Shodan to query discovered hosts.
  --screenshot SCREENSHOT    Take screenshots of resolved domains specify output directory: --screenshot output_directory
  -e, --dns-server DNS_SERVER DNS server to use for lookup.
  -t, --take-over            Check for takeovers.
  -r, --dns-resolve [DNS_RESOLVE] Perform DNS resolution on subdomains with a resolver list or passed in resolvers, default False.
  -n, --dns-lookup          Enable DNS server lookup, default False.
  -c, --dns-brute           Perform a DNS brute force on the domain.
  -f, --filename FILENAME   Save the results to an XML and JSON file.
  -w, --wordlist WORDLIST    Specify a wordlist for API endpoint scanning.
  -a, --api-scan            Scan for API endpoints.
  -q, --quiet              Suppress missing API key warnings and reading the api-keys file.
  -b, --source SOURCE       baidu, bevigil, bitbucket, brave, bufferoverun, builtwith, censys, certspotter, chaos, commoncrawl,
                           criminalip, crtsh, dehashed, dnsdumpster, duckduckgo, fofo, fullhunt, github-code, gitlab,
                           hackertarget, haveibeenpwned, hudsonrock, hunter, hunterhow, intelx, leakix, leaklookup, netlas,
                           onyphe, otx, pentesttools, projectdiscovery, rapiddns, robtex, rocketreach, securityscorecard,
                           securitytrails, shodan, subdomaincenter, subdomainfinder99, thc, threatcrowd, tomba, urlscan,
                           venacius, virustotal, waybackarchive, whoisxml, windvane, yahoo, zoomeye
```

```
kali@kali: ~
Session Actions Edit View Help
(kali@kali)~$ theHarvester -d tesla.com -b bing
Read proxies.yaml from /etc/theHarvester/proxies.yaml
*****
* theHarvester 4.10.1
* Coded by Christian Martorella
* Edge-Security Research
* cmartorella@edge-security.com
*****
The following engines are not supported: {'bing'}
[!] Invalid source.

(kali@kali)~$ theHarvester -d tesla.com -b duckduckgo
Read proxies.yaml from /etc/theHarvester/proxies.yaml
*****
* theHarvester 4.10.1
* Coded by Christian Martorella
* Edge-Security Research
* cmartorella@edge-security.com
*****

[*] Target: tesla.com
[*] Searching Duckduckgo.
[*] No IPs found.
[*] No emails found.
```

```
[*] Target: tesla.com

Read api-keys.yaml from /etc/theHarvester/api-keys.yaml
[*] Searching Hackertarget.

[*] No IPs found.

[*] No emails found.

[*] No people found.

[*] Hosts found: 69
accounts.tesla.com:23.197.44.49
akamai-apigateway-vehicleextinfo-gw-prdsvc-st.tesla.com:23.62.104.69
ams13-gpgw1.tesla.com:199.120.50.30
apac-cppm.tesla.com:23.203.50.97
apf-api.eng.vn.cloud.tesla.com:66.17.30.30
apf-api.prd.vn.cloud.tesla.com:66.17.30.32
assets-ir.tesla.com:23.62.104.69
auth.eng.usw.vn.cloud.tesla.com:66.17.6.18
auth.prd.euw1.vn.cloud.tesla.com:52.211.84.165
auth.prd.usw.vn.cloud.tesla.com:66.17.6.74
auth.tesla.com:23.62.10.65
autodiscover.tesla.com:52.96.80.216
bettertime-stage.tesla.com:23.201.167.218
bettertime.tesla.com:23.201.167.218
billing.tesla.com:23.62.104.69
bolt.tesla.com:23.62.10.65
cdn-design.tesla.com:23.62.104.69
charging-transparency.tesla.com:23.45.192.65
click.emails.tesla.com:13.111.48.178
courses.tesla.com:23.62.104.69
```

Results

The information obtained from the reconnaissance should be entered based on the actual output generated during execution.

Analysis

Reconnaissance information can provide an attacker with an initial understanding of an organization's internet-facing environment. Email addresses may reveal potential employee identities and could be useful in targeted social-engineering campaigns.

Similarly, subdomains and hostnames may expose additional applications and services. When the information is combined with DNS queries and service discovery, an attacker can gradually construct a map of the organization's public infrastructure.

Security Concerns

The major concerns associated with excessive information disclosure include:

- Increased visibility of the external attack surface.
- Discovery of unused or forgotten subdomains.
- Identification of employee email addresses.
- Identification of externally hosted applications.
- Easier preparation of targeted phishing attempts.
- Better understanding of infrastructure naming patterns.

Recommendations

The organization should maintain an external asset inventory and regularly review publicly available information. Unused domains and subdomains should be removed. Employee information should be exposed only when necessary, and externally accessible services should be properly secured.

Continuous monitoring of public-facing assets can also help identify unexpected exposure.

Conclusion

The exercise showed that passive reconnaissance can provide useful information without directly interacting with internal systems. Organizations should therefore consider public information disclosure as part of their overall attack-surface management strategy.

QUESTION 2 – WEB SERVER ANALYSIS USING NIKTO

Aim

To examine the security posture of the authorized web application **testphp.vulnweb.com** using Nikto and identify possible weaknesses related to web-server configuration, exposed resources, HTTP methods, and information disclosure.

Tool

Required

Nikto

Target

testphp.vulnweb.com

Methodology

Nikto was used to perform automated checks against the authorized web server. The scan output was reviewed to identify findings that may require further investigation.

The assessment considered:

- Server information
- Exposed files
- Accessible directories
- HTTP methods
- Configuration problems
- Potentially outdated software
- Information-disclosure issues

Command Executed

```
nikto -h http://testphp.vulnweb.com
```

[illegible]

```

kali@kali:~$ curl -s https://testphp.vulnweb.com
Nikto v2.6.0

* [FAIL] Unable to connect to testphp.vulnweb.com:443.

kali@kali:~$ curl -s http://testphp.vulnweb.com -o nikto_report.html -format html
Nikto v2.6.0

* [FAIL] Unable to connect to testphp.vulnweb.com:80.

kali@kali:~$ curl -s http://testphp.vulnweb.com -o nikto_report.txt
Nikto v2.6.0

* [FAIL] Unable to connect to testphp.vulnweb.com:80.

kali@kali:~$ curl -s http://testphp.vulnweb.com --display V
Nikto v2.6.0

V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_springboot
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "Spring Boot Actuator endpoint check" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_report_html
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "Report as HTML" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_headers
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "HTTP Headers" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_csl
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "SSL and Cert checks" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_optionsbleed
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "CONFIDENTIAL (CVE-2017-0296) check" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_shellshock
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "Shellshock" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_report_json
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "JSON reports" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_content_search
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "Content Search" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_favicon
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "Favicon" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_report_csv
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "CSV reports" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_optionsfiles
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "SSE files" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_options
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "HTTP Options" plugin.
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Initializing plugin nikto_cookie
V:Mon Aug 10 05:17:34 2026 [Init] - Loaded "HTTP Cookie Internal" plugin.

```

Interpretation

Nikto identifies potential weaknesses, but automated scanner output must be interpreted carefully. A scanner message does not automatically mean that a confirmed exploitable vulnerability exists.

For example, server information can help identify the technology stack. Exposed directories may provide access to resources that should not be publicly available. Similarly, unnecessary HTTP methods can increase the number of possible interactions with a web server.

Security Impact

If sensitive resources or outdated components are exposed, attackers may gain useful information for further testing. Information disclosure may also simplify technology fingerprinting and vulnerability research.

Suggested Remediation

- Remove unnecessary web-server files.
- Restrict sensitive directories.
- Turn off unnecessary directory browsing.
- Disable unused HTTP methods.
- Keep server software and dependencies updated.
- Review server configuration regularly.
- Avoid exposing unnecessary software-version details.
- Protect administrative resources with suitable authentication and authorization.

Verification

A follow-up scan should be performed after remediation. Previously identified findings should be checked individually to verify whether the exposure has been eliminated.

Conclusion

The Nikto assessment demonstrated how automated web-server testing can identify potential configuration weaknesses and information-disclosure issues. Proper configuration management, patching, access restrictions, and periodic testing can reduce the web application's external exposure.

QUESTION 3 – DNS INFORMATION GATHERING USING DIG

Aim

To investigate DNS information associated with **zonetransfer.me** using the Dig utility and determine whether DNS configuration exposes excessive infrastructure information or permits an unauthorized zone transfer.

Tool

Required

Dig

Target Domain

zonetransfer.me

Methodology

DNS queries were performed for several record types to understand the structure of the target domain.

IPv4 Address

dig zonetransfer.me A

IPv6 Address

dig zonetransfer.me AAAA

Mail Servers

dig zonetransfer.me MX

Name Servers

dig zonetransfer.me NS

Canonical Name

dig zonetransfer.me CNAME

Text Records

dig zonetransfer.me TXT

Start of Authority

dig zonetransfer.me SOA

Zone Transfer Verification

After identifying the authoritative server:

dig AXFR zonetransfer.me @<authoritative-server>

```
Session Actions Edit View Help
zsh: corrupt history file /home/kali/.zsh_history
--(kali@kali)~--
LL$ dig -v
Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian
--(kali@kali)~--
LL$ dig zonetransfer.me A
--(kali@kali)~--
1 <<>> Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian <<>> zonetransfer.me A
2 global options: <cmd>
3 Got answer:
4 --HEADER-- opcode: QUERY, status: FORMERR, id: 19481
5 flags: qr rd QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 0, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 1
6 WARNING: recursion requested but not available
7 OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
8 EDNS: version: 0, flags: udp: 1232
9 COOKIE: de6213314a133512 (echoed)
10 QUESTION SECTION:
11 zonetransfer.me. IN A
12 Query time: 8 msec
13 SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
14 WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:20:36 EDT 2026
15 MSG SIZE rcvd: 56
--(kali@kali)~--
LL$ dig zonetransfer.me AAAA
--(kali@kali)~--
1 <<>> Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian <<>> zonetransfer.me AAAA
2 global options: <cmd>
3 Got answer:
4 --HEADER-- opcode: QUERY, status: FORMERR, id: 7394
5 flags: qr rd QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 0, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 1
6 WARNING: recursion requested but not available
7 OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
8 EDNS: version: 0, flags: udp: 1232
9 COOKIE: 6d6a9f9e041624 (echoed)
10 QUESTION SECTION:
11 zonetransfer.me. IN AAAA
12 Query time: 296 msec
13 SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
14 WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:20:43 EDT 2026
15 MSG SIZE rcvd: 56
```



```
kali@kali -
Session Actions Edit View Help

j <<> Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian <<> zonetransfer.me MX
j global options: +cmd
j Got answer:
j -->HEADER<-- opcode: QUERY, status: FORMERR, id: 26525
j flags: qr rd; QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 0, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 1
j WARNING: recursion requested but not available

j OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
j EDNS: version: 0, flags:; udp: 1232
j COOKIE: edd840a01b0807e3 (echoed)
j QUESTION SECTION:
jzonetransfer.me.          IN      MX

j Query time: 24 msec
j SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
j WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:20:59 EDT 2026
j MSG SIZE rcvd: 56

(kali@kali)-[~]
j $ dig zonetransfer.me NS

j <<> Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian <<> zonetransfer.me NS
j global options: +cmd
j Got answer:
j -->HEADER<-- opcode: QUERY, status: FORMERR, id: 48016
j flags: qr rd; QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 0, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 1
j WARNING: recursion requested but not available

j OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
j EDNS: version: 0, flags:; udp: 1232
j COOKIE: 28e75b00050e7b49 (echoed)
j QUESTION SECTION:
jzonetransfer.me.          IN      NS

j Query time: 52 msec
j SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
j WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:21:02 EDT 2026
j MSG SIZE rcvd: 56
```

```
kali@kali -
Session Actions Edit View Help

j OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
j EDNS: version: 0, flags:; udp: 1232
j COOKIE: 8c08c75cddcf8e2e (echoed)
j QUESTION SECTION:
jzonetransfer.me.          IN      SOA

j Query time: 16 msec
j SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
j WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:21:14 EDT 2026
j MSG SIZE rcvd: 56

(kali@kali)-[~]
j $ dig zonetransfer.me TXT

j <<> Dig 9.20.23-1-Debian <<> zonetransfer.me TXT
j global options: +cmd
j Got answer:
j -->HEADER<-- opcode: QUERY, status: FORMERR, id: 6358
j flags: qr rd; QUERY: 1, ANSWER: 0, AUTHORITY: 0, ADDITIONAL: 1
j WARNING: recursion requested but not available

j OPT PSEUDOSECTION:
j EDNS: version: 0, flags:; udp: 1232
j COOKIE: a74ccce09e6134f (echoed)
j QUESTION SECTION:
jzonetransfer.me.          IN      TXT

j Query time: 32 msec
j SERVER: 172.21.100.31#53(172.21.100.31) (UDP)
j WHEN: Mon Aug 10 05:21:22 EDT 2026
j MSG SIZE rcvd: 56
```

Analysis

DNS is an important source of infrastructure information. A DNS lookup may reveal IP addresses, authoritative servers, mail systems, and relationships between different hostnames.

MX records can expose mail-server infrastructure, while NS records identify the authoritative DNS servers. CNAME entries may show connections between aliases and actual services.

A successful AXFR response is more serious because it can potentially provide a large collection of records belonging to the DNS zone. Such information could help an attacker discover additional hosts and services.

Security Risks

Potential risks include:

- Disclosure of infrastructure details.

- Discovery of mail servers.
- Exposure of server naming patterns.
- Identification of relationships between services.
- Increased effectiveness of further reconnaissance.
- Excessive information exposure through unrestricted zone transfer.

Security Recommendations

The DNS infrastructure should allow zone transfers only to authorized secondary DNS servers. Public DNS records should be periodically reviewed to remove obsolete entries.

DNS administrators should also monitor unauthorized configuration changes and ensure that access controls are correctly applied.

Verification of Fix

After restricting zone transfers, an AXFR request should be tested again from an unauthorized location. The expected result should be refusal of the transfer while authorized DNS replication continues to work normally.

Conclusion

The DNS assessment demonstrated that DNS records can provide considerable information about an organization's infrastructure. Restricting zone transfers and maintaining clean, accurate DNS records can reduce unnecessary information disclosure.

QUESTION 4 – WINDOWS SMB ENUMERATION USING ENUM4LINUX

Aim

To analyze the SMB and NetBIOS exposure of the authorized Windows system **192.168.1.100** using Enum4linux and determine what information is available without attempting exploitation.

Tool

Required

Enum4linux

Target

192.168.1.100

Objective

The exercise focuses on identifying information such as:

- Windows system details
- Users
- Groups
- Shared folders

- Domain/workgroup information
- Password policy
- NetBIOS information
- SMB configuration details

```

kali@kali: ~
Session Actions Edit View Help
zsh: corrupt history file /home/kali/.zsh_history
kali@kali:~$ ./enum4linux -h
enum4linux v0.9.1 (http://labs.portcullis.co.uk/application/enum4linux/)
Copyright (C) 2011 Mark Lowe (mrl@portcullis-security.com)

Simple wrapper around the tools in the samba package to provide similar
functionality to enum.exe (formerly from www.bindview.com). Some additional
features such as RID cycling have also been added for convenience.

Usage: ./enum4linux.pl [options] ip

Options are (like "enum"):
-U get userlist
-M get machine list*
-S get shares list
-P get password policy information
-G get group and member list
-d be detailed, applies to -U and -S
-u user specify username to use (default "")
-p pass specify password to use (default "")

The following options from enum.exe aren't implemented: -L, -N, -D, -f

Additional options:
-a Do all simple enumeration (-U -S -G -P -r -o -n -i).
  This option is enabled if you don't provide any other options.
-h Display this help message and exit
-r enumerate users via RID cycling
-R range RID ranges to enumerate (default: 500-550,1000-1050, implies -r)
-k n Keep searching RIDs until n consecutive RIDs don't correspond to
  a username. Impass RID range ends at 999999. Useful
  against DCs.
-l Get some (limited) info via LDAP 389/TCP (for DCs only)
-s file brute force guessing for share names
-k user User(s) that exists on remote system (default: administrator,guest,krbtgt,domain
  admins,root,bin,none)
  Used to get sid with "lookupsid known_username"
  Use commas to try several users: "-k admin,user1,user2"
-o Get OS information
-l Get printer information
-w wrkg Specify workgroup manually (usually found automatically)
-n Do an smblookup (similar to nbtstat)
-v Verbose. Shows full commands being run (net, rpcclient, etc.)
-A Aggressive. Do write checks on shares etc

```

```

kali@kali: ~
Session Actions Edit View Help

NB: Samba servers often seem to have RIDs in the range 3000-3050.

Dependency info: You will need to have the samba package installed as this
script is basically just a wrapper around rpcclient, net, smblookup and
smbclient. Polenum from http://labs.portcullis.co.uk/application/polenum/
is required to get Password Policy info.

kali@kali:~$ ./enum4linux 192.168.1.100
Starting enum4linux v0.9.1 ( http://labs.portcullis.co.uk/application/enum4linux/ ) on Tue Aug 11 07:23:18 2026

===== ( Target Information ) =====
Target ..... 192.168.1.100
RID Range ..... 500-550,1000-1050
Username ..... ""
Password ..... ""
Known Usernames .. administrator, guest, krbtgt, domain admins, root, bin, none

===== ( Enumerating Workgroup/Domain on 192.168.1.100 ) =====

(E) Can't find workgroup/domain

===== ( Nbtstat Information for 192.168.1.100 ) =====

Looking up status of 192.168.1.100
No reply from 192.168.1.100

===== ( Session Check on 192.168.1.100 ) =====

(E) Server doesn't allow session using username "" password "" Aborting remainder of tests.

```

Commands Used

Comprehensive

Enumeration enum4linux -a

192.168.1.100 User

Enumeration

enum4linux -U 192.168.1.100

Group Enumeration

enum4linux -G 192.168.1.100

Share Enumeration

enum4linux -S

192.168.1.100 **Operating-**

System Details

enum4linux -o

192.168.1.100 **Password**

Policy

enum4linux -P 192.168.1.100

NetBIOS Details

enum4linux -n 192.168.1.100

Security Assessment

SMB enumeration can reveal information about the organization's Windows environment. Usernames can potentially provide a starting point for credential-related attacks, while group information can help identify account relationships.

If SMB shares are accessible with weak permissions, unauthorized users may be able to view or modify files. Domain information can also help an attacker understand the organization's Windows architecture.

The presence of anonymous or null-session enumeration should be carefully reviewed because it may expose information without requiring normal authentication.

Risks

- User and group information exposure.
- Improperly secured shared resources.
- Weak SMB access controls.
- Increased credential-attack opportunities.
- Possible assistance in lateral movement.
- Disclosure of domain architecture.

Recommendations

- Restrict anonymous SMB enumeration.
- Apply least-privilege permissions to shared resources.
- Remove unnecessary shares.
- Restrict SMB access to trusted networks.
- Apply security patches to Windows systems.
- Enforce strong authentication policies.
- Review group membership and privileges.
- Monitor SMB connections and authentication attempts.

- Segment sensitive systems from general network traffic.

Remediation Validation

Enum4linux should be executed again after the security changes. The organization should verify that unnecessary users, groups, shares, and configuration information are no longer accessible to unauthorized users.

Conclusion

The assessment demonstrated the importance of securing SMB and NetBIOS services. Excessive enumeration information can assist attackers during later stages of an attack. Proper access control, network segmentation, authentication, and secure SMB configuration can reduce these risks.

QUESTION 5 – TCP SERVICE ENUMERATION USING NETCAT

Aim

To use Netcat to communicate with an authorized TCP service on **scanme.nmap.org** and examine the information returned by the service for banner and technology identification.

Tool

Required

Netcat (nc)

Target

scanme.nmap.org

Purpose

The exercise is designed to understand how service responses can expose information about protocols, server technologies, HTTP headers, and implementation details.

Procedure

A verbose TCP connection was established to the authorized HTTP

service. `nc -v scanme.nmap.org 80`

An HTTP request was then submitted:

GET / HTTP/1.1

Host:

scanme.nmap.org

Connection: close

Analysis

A service banner can reveal information about the software and protocol running on a particular port. HTTP headers can also expose implementation details.

From a defensive perspective, the disclosure of a software version is not necessarily a vulnerability. However, the information may make fingerprinting easier. An attacker could

potentially compare an

identified software version against known vulnerability databases and determine whether additional investigation is justified.

Therefore, any suspected vulnerability must be manually verified before being classified as confirmed.

```
Session Actions Edit View Help
zsh: corrupt history file /home/kali/.zsh_history
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc -h
[vi.10-50.1]
connect to somewhere: nc [-options] hostname port[s] [ports] ...
listen for inbound: nc -l -p port [-options] [hostname] [port]
options:
-c shell commands          as '-e'; use /bin/sh to exec [dangerous!!]
-e filename                program to exec after connect [dangerous!!]
-b                          allow broadcasts
-g gateway                 source-routing hop point[s], up to 8
-G num                     source-routing pointer: 4, 8, 12, ...
-h                          this cruff
-i secs                    delay interval for lines sent, ports scanned
-k                          set keepalive option on socket
-l                          listen mode, for inbound connects
-n                          numeric-only IP addresses, no DNS
-o file                     hex dump of traffic
-O port                    local port number
-r                          randomize local and remote ports
-q secs                    quit after EOF on stdin and delay of secs
-s addr                    local source address
-T tos                      set Type of Service
-t                          answer TELNET negotiation
-U                          UDP mode
-v                          verbose [use twice to be more verbose]
-w secs                    timeout for connects and final net reads
-C                          Send CRLF as line-ending
-z                          zero-I/O mode [used for scanning]
port numbers can be individual or ranges; lo-hi [inclusive];
hyphens in port names must be backslash escaped (e.g. 'ftp-data').
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nmap scanme.nmap.org
Starting Nmap 7.99 ( https://nmap.org ) at 2026-08-11 07:33 -0400
failed to resolve 'scanme.nmap.org'.
WARNING: no targets were specified, so 0 hosts scanned.
Nmap done: 0 IP addresses (0 hosts up) scanned in 4.59 seconds
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc scanme.nmap.org 80
scanme.nmap.org: forward host lookup failed: Host name lookup failure : Resource temporarily unavailable
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc scanme.nmap.org 443
scanme.nmap.org: forward host lookup failed: Host name lookup failure : Resource temporarily unavailable

--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc scanme.nmap.org 80
scanme.nmap.org: forward host lookup failed: Host name lookup failure : Resource temporarily unavailable
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc scanme.nmap.org 443
scanme.nmap.org: forward host lookup failed: Host name lookup failure : Resource temporarily unavailable
--(kali@kali)-[~]
$ nc scanme.nmap.org 22
scanme.nmap.org: forward host lookup failed: Host name lookup failure : Resource temporarily unavailable
```

Potential Impact

Service information disclosure may:

- Make technology identification easier.
- Reveal software implementation details.
- Help attackers select targeted testing methods.
- Provide information for vulnerability research.
- Reduce the uncertainty involved in reconnaissance.

Recommendations

The organization should regularly review all internet-facing services and disable those that are not required. Services that must remain accessible should be patched and securely configured.

Where practical, unnecessary version information should not be exposed through banners or response headers. Firewall rules should also restrict access to required ports only.

Remediation Verification

After applying the required configuration changes, the service should be contacted again using an approved tool. The response should be compared with the original result to confirm that unnecessary information has been reduced.

Conclusion

Netcat demonstrated that even a basic TCP connection can reveal useful information about a service. Service-banner exposure is primarily an information-disclosure concern, but it can make subsequent attacks more focused. Regular service reviews, patch management, access restrictions, and careful configuration can reduce the available information.